

Ace Combat

Ace Combat^[a] is an arcade-style combat flight simulation video game series by Project Aces, an internal development team of Bandai Namco Entertainment, formerly Namco. Debuting in 1995 with *Air Combat* for the PlayStation, the series includes eight mainline installments, multiple spin-offs, and other forms of media, such as novels, model kits, and soundtrack albums. Since 2012, the series has been developed primarily by Bandai Namco Studios through its internal development group, Project Aces.

The *Ace Combat* franchise emphasizes fast-paced action and dramatic, anime-styled plots with semi-realistic gameplay; for example, aircraft have flight dynamics controls and can stall, but are also able to carry dozens of missiles. The series features a range of aircraft including accurate or slightly modified representations of modern military aircraft, prototypes that were never adopted (or even built) in real life, and fictional boss-type superweapons. The main series of games is set in "Strangereal", a fictional universe loosely based on the real world, featuring similar events and entities but with an entirely different history largely centering around advanced technology and the aftermath of an asteroid impact event in the 1990s; certain games, however, are set in fictional renditions of the real world.

As of 2023, the *Ace Combat* franchise has shipped over 20 million copies worldwide,^[b] and has established itself as one of the longest running arcade flight action franchises.

<i>Ace Combat</i> ACE COMBAT	
Genre	<u>Combat flight shooter</u>
Developers	<u>Namco</u>
	<u>Bandai Namco Studios</u>
	<u>Access Games</u>
Publishers	<u>Bandai Namco Aces</u>
	<u>Namco</u>
Platforms	<u>Bandai Namco Entertainment</u>
	<u>PlayStation</u> , <u>PlayStation 2</u> , <u>Game Boy Advance</u> , <u>Mobile phone</u> , <u>Xbox 360</u> , <u>Nintendo 3DS</u> , <u>Nintendo Switch</u> , <u>PlayStation 3</u> , <u>PlayStation Portable</u> , <u>Windows</u> , <u>iOS</u> , <u>Xbox One</u> , <u>PlayStation 4</u> , <u>PlayStation 5</u> , <u>Xbox Series X/S</u>
First release	<u><i>Air Combat</i></u> June 30, 1995
Latest release	<u><i>Ace Combat 7: Skies Unknown</i></u> January 18, 2019

Setting

Release timeline

1995	 <u><i>Air Combat</i></u>
1996	
1997	 <u><i>Ace Combat 2</i></u>
1998	
1999	 <u><i>Ace Combat 3: Electrosphere</i></u>
2000	
2001	 <u><i>Ace Combat 04: Shattered Skies</i></u>
2002	
2003	
2004	 <u><i>Ace Combat 5: The Unsung War</i></u>
2005	 <u><i>Ace Combat Advance</i></u>
2006	 <u><i>Ace Combat Zero: The Belkan War</i></u>  <u><i>Ace Combat X: Skies of Deception</i></u>
2007	 <u><i>Ace Combat 6: Fires of Liberation</i></u>
2008	
2009	 <u><i>Ace Combat Xi: Skies of Incursion</i></u>
2010	 <u><i>Ace Combat: Joint Assault</i></u>  <i>Ace Combat Assault Horizon: Trigger Finger</i>
2011	 <u><i>Ace Combat: Assault Horizon</i></u>
	 <u><i>Ace Combat: Assault Horizon Legacy</i></u>  <i>Ace Combat: Northern Wings^[1]</i>
2012	
2013	
2014	 <u><i>Ace Combat Infinity</i></u>
2015	 <i>Ace Combat: Assault Horizon Legacy+</i>
2016	
2017	
2018	
2019	 <u><i>Ace Combat 7: Skies Unknown</i></u>
2020	
2021	
2022	
2023	
2024	
2025	
2026	 <u><i>Ace Combat 8: Wings of Theve</i></u>

Most installments in the *Ace Combat* series are set in "Strangereal", the series' fictional universe. Strangereal's Earth features entirely different nations, geography, continents, and history compared to the real world, though some nations, locations, and events are loosely based on those from real life, and most aircraft in the series are real models with few alterations.

Strangereal is very similar to the real modern world, but with significantly more advanced technology that allows for the development of superweapons and theoretical devices such as aerial warships, laser weapons, railguns, submarine and airborne aircraft carriers, orbital weapons, mass drivers, lethal autonomous weapons, nearly-sentient artificial intelligence, and advanced experimental aircraft. Nuclear weapons exist, but international agreements and nuclear terrorism are implied to have inhibited their development and use, resulting in a lack of nuclear deterrence and a greater focus on conventional weaponry in arms races. This makes large-scale interstate warfare common, and many nations field large militaries with diverse equipment, develop superweapons, train elite special forces-esque "ace" fighter squadrons, or hire mercenaries to augment their forces.

Most *Ace Combat* games are set after a 1999 impact event in which the asteroid "Ulysses 1994XF04", on a collision course with Earth, split into numerous fragments, some of which were destroyed by anti-asteroid weaponry but others still struck the planet, causing widespread destruction and global crises. The international tensions caused by the Ulysses impact and its aftermath play a large role throughout the series, and some of the games' superweapons are, or originate from, anti-Ulysses devices. Another major event in the series' continuity is the 1995 "Belkan War", a World War II-esque conflict in which the advanced ultranationalist nation of Belka attempted to invade neighboring countries during an internal crisis, was repelled by an international coalition, and used nuclear weapons on their own territory to prevent a retaliatory invasion, causing their defeat and earning them global condemnation and scorn; Belkan nationalists seeking revenge for their defeat play major roles in some of the games.

As shown in *Ace Combat 3: Electrosphere*, the nations of Strangereal shown in most of the series are eventually superseded by sovereign megacorporations. Strangereal was later established as part of Bandai Namco's *United Galaxy Space Force* shared universe, representing the earliest period in its timeline, in which the nations of Strangereal unite to form a world government around 2090.^[2]

Ace Combat: Joint Assault, *Assault Horizon*, and *Infinity* are not set in Strangereal, and are instead set in their own fictionalized versions of the real world, albeit with technology similar to Strangereal's.

Games

Title	Year	Platform
Mainline titles		
<u><i>Air Combat</i></u>	1995	<u>PlayStation</u>
<u><i>Ace Combat 2</i></u>	1997	
<u><i>Ace Combat 3: Electrosphere</i></u>	1999	
<u><i>Ace Combat 04: Shattered Skies</i></u>	2001	<u>PlayStation 2</u>
<u><i>Ace Combat 5: The Unsung War</i></u>	2004	
<u><i>Ace Combat Zero: The Belkan War</i></u>	2006	<u>PlayStation 2</u> , <u>PlayStation 5</u> , <u>Windows</u> , <u>Xbox Series X and S</u>
<u><i>Ace Combat 6: Fires of Liberation</i></u>	2007	<u>Xbox 360</u>
<u><i>Ace Combat 7: Skies Unknown</i></u>	2019	<u>Windows</u> , <u>PlayStation 4</u> , <u>Xbox One</u> , <u>Nintendo Switch</u>
<u><i>Ace Combat 8: Wings of Theve</i></u>	2026	<u>Windows</u> , <u>PlayStation 5</u> , <u>Xbox Series X and S</u>
Spin-off titles		
<u><i>Ace Combat: Assault Horizon</i></u>	2011	<u>Windows</u> , <u>PlayStation 3</u> , <u>Xbox 360</u>
<u><i>Ace Combat Infinity</i></u>	2014	<u>PlayStation 3</u>
Handheld console titles		
<u><i>Ace Combat Advance</i></u>	2005	<u>Game Boy Advance</u>
<u><i>Ace Combat X: Skies of Deception</i></u>	2006	<u>PlayStation Portable</u>
<u><i>Ace Combat: Joint Assault</i></u>	2010	
<u><i>Ace Combat: Assault Horizon Legacy</i></u>	2011	<u>Nintendo 3DS</u>
Mobile titles		
<u><i>Ace Combat Xi: Skies of Incursion</i></u>	2009	<u>iOS</u>
<u><i>Ace Combat: Assault Horizon Trigger Finger</i></u>	2010	
<u><i>Ace Combat: Northern Wings</i></u>	2011	<u>J2ME</u>

- ***Air Combat*** (1995) is the debut entry of the series, being released as a launch title for the PlayStation in North America and titled *Ace Combat* in Japan.^[3] Produced by Kazumi Mizuno as a port and successor to a 1993 arcade game of the same name, the plot centers around a team of mercenary pilots hired to defeat a terrorist organization that has seized control of the Skully Islands.^[4] *Air Combat* introduced the series' arcade-like gameplay, a contrast to most other flight sim games at the time. In 2005, *Air Combat* was released for Japanese mobile phones under Namco's game subscription service.^[5]

<i>Ace Combat</i> main chronology
<u><i>Air Combat</i></u> and <u><i>Zero: The Belkan War</i></u> (1995) <u>2</u> and <u><i>Assault Horizon Legacy</i></u> (1997–1998) <u>04: Shattered Skies</u> (2004–2005) <u>5: The Unsung War</u> (2010) <u>6: Fires of Liberation</u> (2015–2016) <u>7: Skies Unknown</u> (2019) <u>X: Skies of Deception</u> (2020) <u>8: Wings of Theve</u> (2029) <u>3: Electrosphere</u> (2040)

- **Ace Combat 2** (1997) was released for the PlayStation, and created out of Namco's dissatisfaction with *Air Combat* from a technical standpoint.^[6] Designed by Masanori Kato, *Ace Combat 2* follows Scarface, a mercenary squadron (the same from *Air Combat*) who are hired again to defeat a coup d'état that threatens the continent of Usea. The sequel builds upon its predecessor in several ways, adding new mission types, playable aircraft, and multiple difficulty options. *Ace Combat 2* was re-released in 2005 for the PlayStation 2 through *NamCollection*, a Japan-exclusive collection of Namco-developed PlayStation games.^[7] In 2011, the game was remade for the 3DS as *Ace Combat: Assault Horizon Legacy*, featuring new levels, an updated plot, and new game mechanics.
- **Ace Combat 3: Electrosphere** (1999) was published for the PlayStation, being the last game in the series for the console. While the previous two games carry a modern-day aesthetic, *Electrosphere* uses a futuristic aesthetic and setting,^[8] and follows a conflict between the megacorporations Neucom and General Resource, and the peacekeeping organization UPEO, in a dystopia where corporations have superseded nation states to compete for power.^[9] *Electrosphere* is heavily reliant on story, with branching stage paths and anime-style video emails with full voice acting. The international versions of the game cut down much of its story and content to accommodate for financial constraints.^[10]
- **Ace Combat 04: Shattered Skies** (2001) was the first game in the series to be developed by Project Aces, then-known as the "AC04 Project". Released for the PlayStation 2 and renamed *Ace Combat: Distant Thunder* in Europe, it was the first entry in the series to thoroughly flesh out Strangereal as the main setting. Initially intended as a series reboot, *Shattered Skies* returned to the gameplay structure of *Air Combat* and *Ace Combat 2*, with fast-paced action and mission variety in a more linear plot. The game's plot tells the story of Mobius 1, a fighter pilot whose legendary exploits during a continent-wide war become instrumental in stopping the country of Erusea's plans to conquer all of Usea.
- **Ace Combat 5: The Unsung War** (2004) was released for the PlayStation 2, renamed *Ace Combat: Squadron Leader* for Europe. Produced by Kazutoki Kono and Project Aces, *The Unsung War* is one of the most expansive titles in the series, with over 50 playable aircraft and 32 campaign missions, along with fully animated cutscenes. The plot follows the members of Wardog Squadron, who uncover a conspiracy fueling a large-scale war between the global superpowers of Osea and Yuktobania. The game also features an arcade mode, following Mobius 1 on a mission to defeat Erusean holdouts. In 2018, Bandai Namco Entertainment re-released *The Unsung War* for the PlayStation 4 as a pre-order bonus for *Ace Combat 7*, with slight modifications to allow it to run properly on the console's hardware.
- **Ace Combat Zero: The Belkan War** (2006) was released for the PlayStation 2, renamed *Ace Combat: The Belkan War* in Europe. It was the last *Ace Combat* game developed by Namco before their assets were folded into Bandai Namco Games, who published the game outside Japan, just a week after its launch in Japan. *The Belkan War* serves as a prequel to *The Unsung War*, combining ideas and mechanics from both it and *Shattered Skies* and explaining plot details and lore mentioned in *The Unsung War*'s story. The plot, told through retrospective narration, recounts the exploits of Galm Team, a pair of mercenary pilots hired to defend the country of Ustio and its allies from an invasion by Belka in 1995. On June 2, 2026, Bandai Namco Entertainment announced *The Belkan War* would be re-released as a pre-order bonus for *Ace Combat 8* on Playstation 5, Xbox Series and PC through Steam, with slight modifications to allow it to run properly on all systems.
- **Ace Combat X: Skies of Deception** (2006) was released for the PlayStation Portable as the first entry in the series to be released on the PSP. The game features the ability for the player to choose their own route through the campaign, allowing for multiple different mission combinations in each playthrough. Its plot follows a war between the neighboring countries of Aurelia and Leasath, and the actions of Aurelia's Gryphus Squadron in the fight against the invading Leasathean forces.

- ***Ace Combat 6: Fires of Liberation*** (2007) was released for the Xbox 360, marking the series' debut on a Microsoft platform. It was the first *Ace Combat* title to implement online multiplayer and downloadable content, which have become staple inclusions since. Alongside a standalone release, Namco Bandai bundled *Fires of Liberation* with the Ace Edge, a flight stick designed by Hori specifically for the game, and a custom Xbox 360 console faceplate. Its story revolves around an invasion of Emmeria by the neighboring country of Estovakia, and the subsequent efforts of Emmerian forces to take back their country, led by the pilots of Garuda Team. In 2018, Bandai Namco Entertainment re-released *Fires of Liberation* for the Xbox One as a pre-order bonus for *Ace Combat 7*, with slight modifications to allow it to run properly on the console's hardware.
- ***Ace Combat: Joint Assault*** (2010) was released for the PlayStation Portable as the first game in the series to be set in the real world. The game's campaign features cooperative gameplay for up to four players, and new aerial combat mechanics that simplify dogfights. *Joint Assault*'s plot follows the pilots of Martinez Security, a private military company hired to help defeat a heavily armed global terrorist force.
- ***Ace Combat: Assault Horizon*** (2011) was released for the PlayStation 3 and Xbox 360, with a later release for Microsoft Windows in 2013 through Steam. *Assault Horizon* features significant gameplay differences compared to other entries in the series, such as a "dogfight mode" and "airstrike mode" to simplify gameplay, a "gritty" *Call of Duty*-esque art direction, and unique turret sections for helicopters, gunships, and bombers, the first time in the series that these types of aircraft are playable. Set in the real world, but in a different universe than *Joint Assault*, the game's plot follows the 108th Task Force, a joint coalition of U.S. and Russian forces deployed to defeat heavily armed insurgencies and criminal organizations.
- ***Ace Combat Infinity*** (2014) was released for the PlayStation 3 as the series' first free-to-play entry. The game featured expansive multiplayer modes and a freemium model. Set in the real world, but in a different universe than *Joint Assault* and *Assault Horizon*, *Infinity* follows the aftermath of a real-world Ulysses incident and the rise of a terrorist organization in devastated Eurasia, with the United Nations enlisting several private military companies to fight back. *Infinity*'s services were discontinued in 2018, with its plot left on a cliffhanger.
- ***Ace Combat 7: Skies Unknown*** (2019) was published for the PlayStation 4, Xbox One, and PC through Steam, and was the first mainline installment released in twelve years. A Nintendo Switch port was published in 2024. *Skies Unknown* was created based on the commercial success of *Ace Combat Infinity*, with its mechanics being borrowed from both it and *Ace Combat: Assault Horizon*. Designed by Project Aces and headed by producer Kazutoki Kono, *Skies Unknown* features multiple additions to the series, including multiple game modes, enhancements to the aircraft tuning concept from *Ace Combat X*, and virtual reality support through PlayStation VR. Returning to the series' traditional setting of Strangereal, the game, set during a war between Osea and Erusea over a space elevator, follows the exploits of Trigger, an Osean pilot who is tasked with clearing his name after a false accusation of murder lands him in a penal squadron. The game also features three VR missions set five years before the campaign, following Mobius 1's continued fight against the Erusean holdouts seen in *The Unsung War*'s arcade mode.
- ***Ace Combat 8: Wings of Theve*** (2026) was confirmed to be in development in August 2021 and had its reveal during the 2025 Game Awards. It is being developed by Bandai Namco Aces. The game is set during the invasion of the Federation of Central Usea (FCU) by the country of Sotoa. It follows a veteran FCU squadron known as the "Wings of Theve", led by the legendary ace "Rex". The player character is Rex's co-pilot who inherits his callsign and position after the former's death.^{[11][12][13]} On June 2, 2026, Bandai Namco's official YouTube channel posted a video detailing the release date of the game. It is confirmed that the game will release October 2nd, 2026 for PlayStation 5, Xbox Series and PC through Steam. Early Access for this game is available on September 29th, 2026 via the Digital Deluxe Edition of the game.^[14]

Title differences

Some *Ace Combat* games have differences in their title, depending on the region (NTSC or PAL) the game was sold in:

- The Japanese *Ace Combat* was renamed *Air Combat* in the North American and European releases of the original game. The second game was initially set to be released as *Air Combat 2* in the U.S., but by the time of release the game (and series) switched to using *Ace Combat* internationally.^[15]
- In NTSC territories, the fourth installment of the series is known as *Ace Combat 04: Shattered Skies*, while in PAL territories the game is known as *Ace Combat: Distant Thunder*. The Spanish version of the game is known as *Ace Combat: Trueno de Acero*, which can be translated as *Ace Combat: Steel Thunder*.
- The NTSC version of the fifth installment of the game is known as *Ace Combat 5: The Unsung War*, while the PAL release was renamed *Ace Combat: Squadron Leader*.
- In PAL territories, the word "Zero" in *Ace Combat Zero: The Belkan War* was removed, making it the first game since the series introduction to not have a significant name change in PAL territories.
- *Ace Combat: Assault Horizon Legacy* in English-speaking territories was originally titled *Ace Combat 3D: Cross Rumble* in Japan.

Printed media

With the release of *Assault Horizon* in 2011, Project Aces created *Aces at War: A History*, a special artbook detailing the content from *Ace Combat 04*, 5, and *Zero* from an in-universe perspective, as well as production commentary. This was packaged with the special editions of *Assault Horizon* released in Japan.^{[16][17]} *Aces at War: A History* would later be updated and rereleased as part of a special edition of *Ace Combat 7: Skies Unknown*.^[18]

In March 2012, ASCII Media Works released *Ace Combat: Ikaros in the Sky*. A tie-in novel for *Assault Horizon*, *Ikaros* tells a story of series character Kei Nagase as she participates in the JASDF's ASF-X Shinden II fighter program.^[19]

Reception

Ace Combat has been a consistent commercial success, with most mainline installments reaching over one million units shipped. *Ace Combat 7: Skies Unknown* is the most successful title with over 7 million copies shipped by 2026,^[30] followed by *Ace Combat 04: Shattered Skies* and *Air Combat*.^[20] The games have sold well predominantly in North America and Japan, where over 75% of all revenue was generated from the series by 2008.^[20] In total, the *Ace Combat* franchise has shipped over 20 million copies.^{[b][34]}

Sales and aggregate review scores

Game	Units sold	Metacritic	OpenCritic
<i>Air Combat</i>	2.23 million shipped ^[20]	—	—
<i>Ace Combat 2</i>	1.092 million shipped ^[20]	83/100 ^[21]	—
<i>Ace Combat 3: Electrosphere</i>	1.164 million shipped ^[20]	—	—
<i>Ace Combat 04: Shattered Skies</i>	2.64 million shipped ^[20]	89/100 ^[22]	—
<i>Ace Combat 5: The Unsung War</i>	1.802 million shipped ^[20]	84/100 ^[23]	—
<i>Ace Combat Advance</i>	100,000 shipped ^[20]	56/100 ^[24]	—
<i>Ace Combat Zero: The Belkan War</i>	792,000 shipped ^[20]	75/100 ^[25]	—
<i>Ace Combat X: Skies of Deception</i>	476,000 shipped ^[20]	75/100 ^[26]	—
<i>Ace Combat 6: Fires of Liberation</i>	700,000 ^[27]	80/100 ^[28]	—
<i>Ace Combat: Assault Horizon</i>	1.07 million ^[27]	78/100 ^[29]	—
<i>Ace Combat 7: Skies Unknown</i>	7 million ^[30]	80/100 (PS4) ^[31]	79% recommend ^[32]

See also



- *Air Combat 22*
- *Project Wingman*
- *Tom Clancy's H.A.W.X*
- *The Sky Crawlers: Innocent Aces*, a spiritual spin-off released exclusively on the *Wii* as a tie-in for the film *The Sky Crawlers*

Notes

- Japanese: エースコンバット, Hepburn: *Ēsu Konbatto*
- Over 14 million copies shipped by 2018,^[33] plus over 7 million copies sold of *Ace Combat 7: Skies Unknown* after its release in 2019.^[30]

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External links

- [Ace Combat official website \(http://www.acecombat.jp/\)](http://www.acecombat.jp/)
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